

Dialectic and a Realist Informed-Desire Account of Good

I.

There have been a number of recent attempts by contemporary Utilitarians to identify certain desires/inclinations as normative in virtue of their being elicited in response to an agent's adequate perception of his or her options. These attempts have been variously packaged in analyses of rational desires, of the aim of prudent action, of the good for any given individual, or of wellbeing.⁽¹⁾ A central desirable feature of all such informed-desire accounts is the promise in them for overcoming the rigid separation between facts and values. It seems plausible that there may be some fact to the matter about what desires will be elicited in a given individual by sufficiently rich experiences of certain options; for example, the experience of acute physical pain suffered to no apparent purpose may as a matter of fact produce in a given human being (or in all of us) a desire for the alleviation of that pain. If there are facts such as these about how human beings would incline under adequately informed circumstances, they may provide a foundation for a realist account of morality. For perhaps morality can be analyzed in terms of the promotion of human wellbeing, whether along Utilitarian lines or in some other way.

In this essay I want to consider two problem areas for informed-desire accounts, problem areas which have thus far been underexplored by informed-desire theorists. My purpose is not only to offer an improved informed-desire account, but also to draw attention to the particular way of understanding the nature of rationality which both illuminates and resolves the difficulties facing contemporary informed-desire accounts. MacIntyre has called this view of rationality upon which I will draw the rationality of craft-tradition. But as MacIntyre notes, this view of rationality has its origins in Plato. So I will draw freely from the *Republic* to illustrate Plato's anticipation of both the difficulties and their resolutions discussed here.

II.

Informed-desire accounts of good⁽²⁾ attempt to pick out certain desires as

normative on the basis of the amount and kind of information to which those desires are or would be responses. Any informed-desire account which hopes to provide facts about human good to serve as a foundation for a realist moral theory will depend on there being two additional kinds of facts. First, there must be facts about whether or not a certain compilation of information is normative; for example, if normative information is analyzed as all that information which would in fact affect which desires are formed, then there would need to be facts about which information would affect which desires are formed. Second, there must be facts about how a given human being's desires/inclinations would respond to information of the normative sort. With regard to both these prerequisite kinds of facts--facts about the information, and facts about the desires--the specter of relativism rears its head.

Which perceptions of a given option count as information about that option will depend upon what is true about the world within which that option is situated. Whether a sexual advance from a colleague is in fact an opportunity or a temptation depends in part on whether there is in fact a kingdom of God (and of what sort) from which fornicators might find themselves disinherited.⁽³⁾ If the claim that sexual pleasure in a given set of circumstances is good turns out to depend on whether or not Christianity (or any other religion or worldview) is true, then the pathway to moral realism through a realist informed-desire account of good would seem to be more complicated than might be supposed. That path is yet more complicated when we consider not just whether any given worldview is true, but whether it makes any sense to claim that a given worldview might be true. Any version of the problem of relativism which challenges the claims to veracity among rival world views would seem at the same time to pose a problem for any normative account of information about one's options. Thomas Kuhn argued in 1962 and MacIntyre since 1984 that when one pays attention not only to the superficial conflicts among rival worldviews but also to the existence of rival standards for judging rival claims, the problem of relativism regarding competing worldviews is quite large indeed. Relativism seems no less serious a problem when specifying which information is normative in desire-formation than it is regarding any other candidate domain of fact.

A second relativist challenge faces the informed-desire theorist. Informed-desire accounts pick out those desires as privileged or normative which are elicited in

response to consideration of some appropriate measure of information. Given the possession of any such measure of information, it would seem that which desires are elicited in response would depend not only on the information presented but also on any disposition and habituation present in the agent due to past experiences. Moreover, it seems possible that different prior formations could produce different responses to information about any given option. Suppose we ask: which sorts of prior formations affect our responses to future information about our options in ways that are good?

We might respond, as good informed-desire theorists, that prior formation is good for an agent just in case that agent would desire to have been formed in that way, given adequate information about rival ways to have been formed. But any human being's assessment of rival ways in which he or she might have been formed is an assessment by a human being who has already undergone some prior formation. That prior formation might well have had an ineliminable effect on which attitude that person would take toward rival ways in which he or she might have been formed. Insofar as it does, it seems that what is desired by human beings given even normative information is in some measure relative to their prior formation. Since the good for human beings is to be cast in terms of these normatively-elicited desires, the good for human beings will be in some measure relative to prior formation.

Informed-desire theorists hope to ground a realist account of morality on questions of fact about what is good for human beings. It would seem that the prospects of doing so are not independent of attempts to explain human behavior on socially or culturally-determined models, any more than they are independent of debates over relativism in other candidate domains of fact.

III.

There is a promising direction for resolving both these relativist impediments to an informed-desire grounding of a realist approach to morality. In recent work Alasdair MacIntyre has sought to revive the craft-tradition approach to rational inquiry, which he ascribes to the tradition of Plato, Aristotle, and Aquinas.

Rational inquiry, on the craft-tradition model, is ultimately wholistic, aiming that the assemblage of a comprehensive, unified account of what is true and of what

should be done. On this model, theoretical and practical inquiry are inseparable, as are intellectual and moral development, since there are true propositions about what is good, and since the truth is a particular kind of good. Whole systems of thought and practice are justified as wholes by their power to persuade: power to elicit assent (on the theoretical side of inquiry) and to elicit inclination (on the practical side of inquiry.) This power to persuade is revealed in the contest for allegiance among those intellectually and morally mature inhabitants of rival systems who are at the same time able to adequately grasp the merits of their own and rival systems, on their own and their rivals' own terms. The problems of rival standards of truth and of goodness, and thus the two problems with relativism sketched earlier, are overcome through a process in which members of a given tradition find resources in their own tradition for persuading members of rival traditions on that rival tradition's own standards that it is in some way inferior, less persuasive, than its rival tradition. Rival and incommensurable standards of truth or goodness do not pose an obstacle to rational agreement in cases where both sets of standards can be shown to point to the same conclusion.

Plato's *Republic* brilliantly illustrates this craft-tradition strategy for overcoming relativism. Plato was contending, first, with a rival account of reality and of truth—the claimed priority of seeming over being, of rhetorical effectiveness over truth, represented in the dialogue by the "great shower of speech" (344d) from Thrasymachus. But he also was concerned with readers who had rival prior formations and rival pictures of what is desirable, represented in the dialogue by his teacher and his own two brothers, Socrates, Glaucon, and Adeimantus, members of the "three primary classes of human beings--wisdom-loving, victory-loving, and profit-loving" (581c.)

Plato's task in the *Republic* is to discuss the nature of justice and its relationship to the good life in a way which is effectively persuasive both to those with rival views of the nature of reality and truth, as well as to those with rival prior formations and thus with rival views of the good life. He does so by representing Socrates as recounting a conversation he had had with Glaucon and Adeimantus, during the course of which Socrates presents an overview of the nature of being, of knowledge and opinion, of truth and goodness, of human nature, human destiny, and human education which is persuasive to all participants in the discussion. In having Socrates provide this account in a dramatic context, Plato is

giving us a demonstration of the craft of persuading persons with rival worldviews and rival characters, as well as of the craft of discovery and justification of the truth. Education is the process of turning the whole soul of a human being--another's, or one's own--toward what is true, beautiful, and good, consisting of these two sides, teaching and discovery (518c, d). Dialectic is its coping stone (534e).

Dialectic is the process of arriving at an account, an overview, of a whole system of thought and practice. Hypotheses, the first principles which are taken for granted in other kinds of inquiry, are--by comparing them in a justificatory context with rival possibilities--destroyed *as hypotheses* in dialectic (533d). From the resulting uncertainty (533d) dialectic takes certain of the candidate first principles drawn from every area of inquiry and unites them into a coherent, persuasive whole(4), presented in an account which will stand up against rival accounts (534b,c). First principles from each area of inquiry are secured in this process in virtue of the essential role they play in the construction of a whole superior to its rivals in the insight and benefit contained.(5)

But on whose standards can one whole system be shown to be superior to any rival account? Both accounts must be constructed from rival candidates for first principles taken from every area of inquiry. Included among those rival first principles might be the first principles of practical rationality, that is, rival views of what is good for human beings, as well as rival assumptions about the nature of reality, humanity, rationality, education, and truth. Whose first principles--Glaucou's, or Socrates', say--and whose standards of success--those of the rhetorician Thrasymachus or of the philosopher Socrates--are we to use to judge the outcome of the contest? The answer must be: everyone's first principles, everyone's standards. The strategy to pursue in persuading Glaucou on his own terms must be different from that used in persuading Thrasymachus on his. Argument at the level of systemic confrontation is not universal and impersonal, but tailored to the particular adherent of the particular rival system. The superiority of Socrates' worldview is demonstrated by the resources it affords him to "go down into a person's character and examine it thoroughly" (577a) and construct a defense on Glaucou's own terms of as near to Socrates' own understanding of the world as Glaucou can both be led to and benefit from in a long evening's conversation. Thus, the claim that justice is the proper

ordering of all of the parts of the soul toward the best life, the pursuit of wisdom, is spoon-fed to Glaucon's disordered soul by sugar-coating it with a good measure of honor and sexual license (465d and 537b-d; 468b,c), in effect "gently persuading him while hiding from him the fact that he's not healthy" (476e).

Thrasymachus, meanwhile, suffers from a more serious disorder of soul which is not only--as Glaucon's is--indifferent to the truth (see 535e, and then 529c) but hostile to it. Socrates' strategy for persuading Thrasymachus to value wisdom is much like the way one might persuade someone threatening immediate suicide to value his or her own life--first, with a set of handcuffs, and then with kindness. Thrasymachus is handcuffed in speech by being persuaded that he can no longer win a good reputation for himself (follow the drama at 338a, 341b, 343a, 348a, 350d,e), and he is kept out of a discussion he could only harm even while being subjected to a more powerful rhetorical exercise than he himself could muster (341b); all this, to the benefit of Thrasymachus (498d.)

So the persuasion of Glaucon and Thrasymachus is accomplished by appeal to their own standards. Glaucon comes to agree that the pursuit of justice and wisdom, its fruit, is the best life, bringing with it in the long run more of what he values--honor and pleasure--than other kinds of lives. Thrasymachus comes to see that justice is best left unchallenged as a great good—at least among the young men gathered in the house of Cephalus--since its defender is better able to construct a persuasive case for that claim than Thrasymachus can for its denial. But these persuasions--for Glaucon, to pursue wisdom for pleasure's and honor's sake; for Thrasymachus, to protect his reputation by remaining silent--are not of course persuasions to the whole of the system Socrates is represented as holding.

Persuasion to that whole would require their grasping the world with a stability analogous to that which Socrates has achieved, which would require a full ascent from the cave, a complete turning of the whole soul, a complete transformation of thought and desire. Socrates takes each character as far down the path as each can follow (533a), without revealing to them--even at the end of their conversation--the whole of the system to which they are now nearer (543d.) Plato treats his readers in the same manner.

Plato presents Socrates as accomplishing the persuasion of his interlocutors in

virtue of his accurate grasp of their thought and character, a grasp which comes through imaginative participation in their lives (577a, b; 578d-580). That insight is proven in the reproduction of their thought and character at each step in the process of persuasion, steps which are effective precisely because Socrates has anticipated the next stage in the development of the thinking and desiring of his interlocutors. Socrates has entered into the lives of his interlocutors. *Mimesis*, imitation, of the entire thought and character of adherents of rival systems, is an essential element of persuading them on their own terms. It is the art of imagery, and Plato shows himself a master of it in his representation of Socrates.

Socrates is an imitator on at least two levels in the *Republic*. He is, first, imitating an adherent of positions he does not hold (354b,c; 368b; 375d; 394d; 397a; etc.), Second, Plato gives us Socrates as--at one level--the only character in the dialogue; the speech of all the other characters is imitated by Socrates, who narrates minimally and imitates each of the representatives of bad forms of human beings with whom he presents himself as having dialogued. Socrates is presented as violating his own prescriptions against imitating the bad (396a), embodying the style of mixed imitation and narration ascribed to epic poetry (394c). Plato himself hides (393d) entirely behind the character of Socrates. While the imitation which Socrates the narrator represents himself as undertaking in the dialogue is directed to the persuasion of the characters in the dialogue, Plato's imitation is not directed towards these characters. Then to whom?

Socrates is presented as the type of the philosopher in the *Republic*. To interpret Plato, we must interpret Socrates. Socrates in the *Republic* is not represented as addressing Glaucon or Adeimantus; he is represented as addressing the listeners to his recounting of his conversation with Glaucon and Adeimantus. The real positions of Plato's character Socrates are hidden in his speech, both at the level of his reported speech to Glaucon and Adeimantus, and at the level of his speech to those listening to the recounting of the conversation. Socrates is providing these listeners with a vast range of double meanings, of shadowy speech, which these listeners must piece together for themselves to grasp Socrates' real meaning. What Socrates represents himself as having done with the young men in the dialogue is to persuade them on their own terms toward an account of all that is true and good greater than any the young men already accept. But Socrates' speech contains countless clues that the account toward which he is

leading these young men is not exactly the same as that to which they think they have been led. On central points discussed in the dialogue--especially the nature of the Good, of education, and of poetry and dialectic in particular--the doctrine Socrates hints toward is far richer than the doctrine he discusses with his younger acquaintances. Socrates' arguments for the superficial level of doctrine are generally poor--sometimes ridiculous--if viewed as parts of a treatise on the same subjects. But they are poor or ridiculous in ingeniously revealing ways. Socrates' speech aims to meet three standards: that of persuasion of his interlocutors; that of comic revelation to his listeners of his interlocutors; and that of providing a pathway toward deeper insight. As these poor arguments are used to turn the souls of the young men in the dialogue, so the narrative itself--the *Republic* is misleadingly called a dialogue--is directed toward turning the souls of Socrates' listeners. To be turned they must attend to every detail, applying everything else they know with sufficient skill and good intention to discover what Socrates is really doing and saying.

In the *Republic* Plato the philosopher gives us the narrative of Socrates the philosopher for the same purpose: to turn the souls of his readers. Plato is addressing those familiar with the doctrines of the Pythagoreans, of Parmenides and Heraclitus, and with epic poetry as well as contemporary Athenian comedy and tragedy; he has constructed a system which captures the wealth of insight from each of these sources. (There may be others.) That insight is packaged, as Allan Bloom noted in his translation of the text, in a microcosm of the world it illuminates. Plato's *Republic* *is* Plato's cave: the text is a narrative of revealing illusion which requires the very same arduous exercise of the very same interpretive powers, moral and intellectual, to grasp its meaning as are required to understand the world, to ascend from the cave, to turn the soul, one's own or another's.

In requiring this assent toward proper interpretation of the text, Plato is not imposing an arbitrary or unnecessary task on his readers. The insight and benefit contained in the account of the world which Plato holds cannot be acquired without the sort of moral and intellectual conversion required to interpret the *Republic*. One cannot adequately assess the power to elicit assent and inclination contained in a whole system until one grasps it fully, and grasping it requires experiential knowledge of what it would be like to be a person who is morally

and intellectually mature as that system defines maturity. In presenting a pathway toward the true and the good in a genre which requires an arduous intellectual and moral exercise to interpret his meaning, Plato provides us with a pathway to undergo the very sort of transformation required for an adequate embracing of both.

IV.

Plato's *Republic* not only discusses central features of the craft-tradition procedure for confronting the problem of relativism, but at three levels—those of Socrates' discussion, of Socrates' narration, and of Plato's imitation of Socrates--the text models that procedure. The craft-tradition model of rationality confronts problems of relativism by first situating them in conflicts between whole systems of thought and practice, and then by achieving rational consensus among adherents of these rival systems by appeals addressed uniquely to each participant in the debate, appeals drawing on the standards internal to the system to which each participant adheres. Effective use of such appeals requires the possession of at least as good an understanding of any given rival system as the adherent of that system possesses. Superior systems, such as the one Socrates demonstrates in conversation with Glaucon and Adeimantus, afford an even better understanding of rival systems than the inhabitants of those systems themselves possess: so say these converts themselves.

In the clash of rival systems with rival standards, any given system is justified--is shown to have a persuasive power which can endure the test of comparison with rival systems--only as the best-system-to-emerge-so-far from past contests. In the history of contest among rival systems of thought and practice, these enduring systems--call them traditions--identify, hone, and increase their resources for successful resolution of their own theoretical and practical problems, as well as for persuading the mature members of rival traditions on these rivals' own terms of the superiority of this best-system-so-far. In the narrative history of the personal conversions of mature inhabitants of insightful and beneficial rival traditions to a yet superior tradition, that superior system locates its justification.(6)

The *Republic* initiates a tradition of inquiry, and challenges its readers from

every rival tradition to become transformed by the process of interpretation of the text into persons who are able to assess on their own terms the merits of the system which guided the writing of the text. There is an account of the Good in the *Republic*, but no adequate assessment of it is possible without an interpretive ascent out of the text and into the insight of the Platonic system.

That account of the Good seems akin to informed-desire accounts, since the form of the Good and what participates in that form is--Plato claims--the object of informed desire. But to become rightly informed, on the craft-tradition model, one must attain maturity in a whole system of thought and practice, coming to appreciate firsthand the power of that system to elicit assent and inclination. Information about the good is information about what it is like to be a certain kind of person; information requires moral formation. The person who is in a position to develop an adequately informed inclination toward becoming a mature member of one tradition in preference to a given rival, is a person who has achieved maturity in one tradition, and who has through imaginative participation in the lives of others experienced the merits of maturity in its rival. The merits of any particular experience can only be adequately assessed insofar as that experience is part of a whole life, guided by some whole system of thought and practice. Judgments about particular goods--judgments which form the first principles of practical inquiry--are justified in virtue of their place in a whole, just as any other first principles are.(7)

It would seem, then, that there is an informed-desire account available with the resources to both characterize and overcome the challenge of relativism, a challenge which seems to stand in the way of an informed-desire route to a realist account of morality. The problem of rival worldviews with rival standards of truth and goodness is easily identified from a perspective accustomed to holistic inquiry, and the craft-tradition strategy of persuading on both sets of rival standards opens the possibility of rational consensus even on rival standards of inquiry. The problem of the effects on the formation of desire from experiences prior to choice is easily identified from a perspective accustomed to attending to the interdependence of intellectual and moral formation, and the craft-tradition emphasis on imaginative inhabitation in rival systems suggests the tailoring of argument to not only the intellect but also the character of persons with different and rival prior formations. The good is roughly what one would

desire if adequately informed, but the craft-tradition model of rational inquiry reveals that adequately informing human beings about their options is a far more intense and challenging problem than has been noticed in previous discussions of informed-desire accounts.

Finally, it would be a mistake to present Plato's account of the Good as if some modified informed-desire account of good might adequately capture it. One cannot adequately understand any single aspect of Plato's (or any) worldview without understanding its place in the whole. We cannot understand the form of the Good by giving an account of it as a separated and abstract concept. Plato's form of the Good and all that participates in that form are objects of informed (enlightened) desire. But they are just as much sources of life. Self-donation characterizes the form of the good just as much as does its being the object of informed desire. The kind of life modeled by Socrates is not only the most desirable of lives, but also the most self-giving of lives.⁽⁸⁾ Whether or not these two dimensions of the Platonic account of the form of the Good are in harmony is an important question--in the *Republic* and for moral theory--but one which must remain for another occasion.

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1 See Richard Brandt, *A Theory of the Right and the Good*, (Oxford: Clarendon Press), 1979. Without discussing here Brandt's view of the relationship between rational desires and good, we can say that Brandt is sympathetic to informed-desire accounts of good (see p. 127.) See James Griffin, *Wellbeing* (Oxford: Clarendon Press), 1988; Peter Railton, "Facts and Values", in *Phil Topics XIV*, No. 2, Fall 1986.

2 For the sake of brevity I will discuss only informed-desire accounts of good (such as Railton's), and suppose that appropriate adjustments in terminology can be made for similar accounts of wellbeing or of rational desires.

3 See 1 Corinthians 6: 9.

4 At 511b, Grube-Reeve translates "(reason, by the power of dialectic) does not

consider these hypotheses as first principles but as stepping stones to take off from, enabling it to reach the unhypothetical first principle of everything." Bloom, in an alternative rendering to his own text, offers "...to reach the beginning, which is the whole." (see p. 191, n. 38, in either the 1968 or the 1991 printing.) Bloom's alternative translation seems to me to best capture the meaning of dialectic as it is actually modeled in Socrates' activity throughout the dialogue.

5 "Grasp it correctly as a whole, and it will seem perfectly plain to you" (491c), Plato has Socrates say to Adeimantus in one of the many "tracks" of dialectic dispersed throughout the dialogue. Another is at 537c: "anyone who can achieve a unified vision is dialectical. On "tracks" laid throughout the dialogue, see 368c, 430e, 432b-d, 462a.

6 In [Three Rival Versions of Nonmoral Goodness](#), Hancock, Curtis L., and Anthony O. Simon, ed.s, *Freedom, Virtue, and the Common Good*, American Maritain Association, 1995, I address the problem of whether the amount of information which has justificatory relevance to claims about what is good is beyond the cognitive capacity of human beings. See also my "[Freedom and Good in the Thomistic Tradition](#)", *Faith and Philosophy*, Vol. 11, No. 3, July 1994. Find links to both papers [here](#).

7 The following is something like the analysis I have in mind: A state of affairs S is good for person P (at t) if S is actualizable (at t) and is such that for any other state of affairs S' which is actualizable (at t) and noncompossible with S, P would prefer S to S' in choice situations where P had full knowledge of both S and S', were P to conceive of both S and S' from the standpoint of a mature inhabitant of that tradition T which is both inhabitable by P, and is such that for any rival tradition (inhabitable by P) T' where full knowledge of both T and T' is compossible for P, P would prefer to inhabit T over T' in light of that full knowledge. A fuller account of full knowledge—roughly, enough knowledge so that no more will affect how one chooses—and of the justification for this account is given in my *Three Rival Versions of Nonmoral Goodness*.

8 On this point as on many others my many discussions with Mark Moes of Grand Valley State have made it difficult for me to separate my own insights from his. I acknowledge this debt, and our friendship.